claim the home ministry was worried that Ramdev had strong connections with the RSS and the entire Sangh Parivar, which is why there was a sense of fear of what could happen next.

The fact is, just weeks earlier, the government had faced a similar crisis when Anna Hazare's fast against corruption had led to massive protests. In the face of a seemingly gigantic mobilization against corruption, covered relentlessly on TV, the UPA had run terrified and cowered behind dithering officialese about media-manufactured movements. Seriously rattled, confronted by a ringing repudiation of its moral authority at its doorstep, clueless on how to gain the upper hand over disobedient crowds exploding from every TV set, the government certainly didn't want a repeat of the Anna paroxysm. In the end, the UPA got exactly what it didn't want—more public opprobrium. Anna first, and then Ramdev—2011 would turn out to be the UPA's annus horribilis, perhaps setting the agenda for a general election that was still three years away.

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When Anna Hazare arrived in Delhi on 4 April 2011 to go on a fast against corruption, the country was caught up in cricket World Cup fever. Mahendra Singh Dhoni's Men in Blue had captured the hearts and minds of a nation. On 2 April, when Dhoni hit the six that lifted the trophy, the nation was euphoric and united. Television channels endlessly replayed images of Dhoni, Tendulkar, Yuvraj and the other heroes who had lit up the Mumbai skyline on that magical day. Even the politicians, led by Sonia Gandhi, were out on the streets waving the tricolour. Just three days later, the same Indian public had found an unlikely hero in a septuagenarian Gandhian activist from the small village of Ralegan Siddhi in Maharashtra. Television channels had a delicious new story to tell. Only, this time the politicians were on the wrong side of the divide in the face of pulsating citizen power.

If Dhoni had made winning the World Cup his goal, Anna came to Delhi with an equally focused mission. He said he was going on an indefinite hunger strike against corruption and demanded the implementation of the